

SUPREME COURT OF THE STATE OF NEW YORK
COUNTY OF KINGS

----- X

CHRISTOPHER ELLIS,

Plaintiff,

-against-

SUMMONS

THE CITY OF NEW YORK, POLICE OFFICER
IFTEKHARUL AWAL, Tax No. 950034, SERGEANT
MICHAEL PETRONE, and POLICE OFFICERS JOHN
DOES NUMBERS ONE THROUGH TEN,

Index No.:

The Basis of Venue is:
Location of Incident

Defendants.

Plaintiff designates Kings
County as the place of trial.

----- X

To the above named Defendants:

You are hereby summoned to answer the Verified Complaint in this action, and to serve a copy of your Verified Answer to the Verified Complaint, or, if the Verified Complaint is not served with this Summons, to serve a notice of appearance on the Plaintiff's attorneys within twenty days after the service of this Summons, exclusive of the day of service, where service is made by delivery upon you personally within the state, or, within 30 days after completion of service where service is made in any other manner. In case of your failure to appear or answer, judgment will be taken against you by default for the relief demanded in the complaint.

DATED: New York, New York
November 16, 2018

Yours, etc.

/s/

JACOBS & HAZAN, LLP.
STUART E. JACOBS, ESQ.
Attorney for Plaintiff
30 Vesey Street, 4th Floor
New York, New York 10007
(212) 577-2690

TO: City of New York, Corporation Counsel, 100 Church Street, NY, NY 10007
POLICE OFFICER IFTEKHARUL AWAL, Tax No. 950034, 81st Precinct, 30 Ralph
Ave, Brooklyn, NY 11221
SERGEANT MICHAEL PETRONE, 81st Precinct, 30 Ralph Ave, Brooklyn, NY 11221

SUPREME COURT OF THE STATE OF NEW YORK
COUNTY OF KINGS

----- X
CHRISTOPHER ELLIS,

Plaintiff,

-against-

THE CITY OF NEW YORK, POLICE OFFICER
IFTEKHARUL AWAL, Tax No. 950034, SERGEANT
MICHAEL PETRONE, and POLICE OFFICERS JOHN
DOES NUMBERS ONE THROUGH TEN,

Defendants.
----- X

INDEX NO.:

VERIFIED COMPLAINT

JURY TRIAL DEMANDED

Plaintiff CHRISTOPHER ELLIS, by his attorneys, Jacobs & Hazan, LLP, as and for his
Verified Complaint herein, alleges upon information and belief as follows:

PRELIMINARY STATEMENT

1. This is a civil rights action to recover money damages arising out of defendants' violation of plaintiff's rights as secured by the Civil Rights Act, 42 U.S.C. Sections 1983 and 1988, and of rights secured by the Fourth, Fifth and Fourteenth Amendments to the United States Constitution, and the common law and the laws of the State of New York. On August 18, 2017, at approximately 2:00 p.m., plaintiff Christopher Ellis, while lawfully sitting on a bench in the vicinity of 701 Gates Avenue, Brooklyn, New York, was subjected to an unlawful stop, question, frisk, false arrest, and false imprisonment by the defendant New York City police officers. Plaintiff was denied the right to due process and a fair trial when the defendant police officers forward false, misleading and incomplete information to the District Attorney's Office. Plaintiff was deprived of his constitutional and common law rights when the individual defendants unlawfully stop, questioned, frisked, falsely arrested, falsely imprisoned, and denied plaintiff the rights to due process and a fair trial in violation of the Fourth, Fifth and Fourteenth Amendments to the United States Constitution, the common law and the laws of the State of New York.

PARTIES

2. Plaintiff CHRISTOPHER ELLIS is a resident of the state of New York.

3. POLICE OFFICER IFTEKHARUL AWAL, Tax No. 950034, is and was at all times relevant herein, an officer, employee, and agent of the New York City Police Department.

4. POLICE OFFICER IFTEKHARUL AWAL, Tax No. 950034, is and was at all times relevant herein, assigned to the 81st Precinct

5. POLICE OFFICER IFTEKHARUL AWAL, Tax No. 950034, is being sued in his individual and official capacity.

6. SERGEANT MICHAEL PETRONE is and was at all times relevant herein, an officer, employee, and agent of the New York City Police Department.

7. SERGEANT MICHAEL PETRONE is and was at all times relevant herein, assigned to the 81st Precinct

8. SERGEANT MICHAEL PETRONE is being sued in his individual and official capacity.

9. New York City Police Officers John Does #1-10 are and were at all times relevant herein officers, employees, and agents of the New York City Police Department.

10. Police Officers John Does #1-10 are being sued in their individual and official capacities.

11. At all times relevant herein, the individual defendants were acting under color of state law in the course and scope of their duties and functions as agents, servants, employees and officers of the New York City Police Department, and otherwise performed and engaged in conduct incidental to the performance of their lawful functions in the course of their duties. They were acting for and on behalf of the New York City Police Department at all times relevant herein, with the power and authority vested in them as officers, agents and employees of the New York City Police Department and incidental to the lawful pursuit of their duties as officers, employees and agents of the New York City Police Department.

12. Defendant City of New York is a municipal entity created and authorized under the laws of the State of New York. It is authorized by law to maintain a police department, which acts as its agent in the area of law enforcement and for which it is ultimately responsible. The defendant City of New York assumes the risks incidental to the maintenance of a police force and the employment of police officers as said risks attach to the public consumers of the services provided by the New York City Police Department.

13. Plaintiff in furtherance of his causes of action brought pursuant to New York State law filed a timely Notice of Claim against the CITY OF NEW YORK in compliance with the Municipal Law Section 50 and in accordance with New York State law.

14. In accordance with New York State law and General Municipal Law Section 50, plaintiff testified at a hearing held pursuant to General Municipal Law Section 50-H on December 12, 2017.

15. More than thirty (30) days have elapsed since service of said Notice of Claim was filed and THE CITY OF NEW YORK has failed to pay or adjust the claims.

16. This action falls within one or more of the exceptions as set forth in CPLR Section 1602, involving intentional actions, as well as the defendant, and/or defendants, having acted in reckless disregard for the safety of others, as well as having performed intentional acts.

17. Plaintiff has sustained damages in an amount in excess of the jurisdictional limits of all the lower Courts of the State of New York.

STATEMENT OF FACTS

18. On August 18, 2017, at approximately 2:00 p.m., plaintiff was lawfully sitting on a bench in the vicinity of front of 701 Gates Avenue, Brooklyn, New York when the defendant police officers unlawfully stopped, questioned, frisked, and searched plaintiff without reasonable suspicion or probable cause.

19. At no time relevant herein did plaintiff commit a crime or violate the law, nor did plaintiff behave in a manner that would lead a reasonable police officer to believe that plaintiff committed, was about to commit or was committing a crime.

20. Suddenly, without provocation or legal justification, the defendant police officers grabbed plaintiff unlawfully handcuffed and arrested him.

21. At no time relevant herein did plaintiff act in a physical threatening manner towards the defendant police officers or anyone else, nor did plaintiff resist arrest in any way.

22. At no time relevant herein did the defendant police officers recover any drugs, guns or other contraband from plaintiff or from plaintiff's possession, custody or control.

23. Nevertheless, the defendant police officers unlawfully handcuffed and falsely arrested plaintiff.

24. The handcuffs placed on plaintiff by the defendant police officers were unreasonably tight on plaintiff's wrists, causing plaintiff to suffer pain and discomfort.

25. Plaintiff told the defendant police officers that the handcuffs were hurting his wrists, and asked the defendant police officers to loosen the handcuffs, but the defendant police officers ignored plaintiff and failed to loosen the handcuffs.

26. The unreasonably tight handcuffs were the direct and proximate cause of the physical injuries to plaintiff's wrists.

27. Plaintiff was transported by the defendant police officers to the 81st Precinct against his will, where he was photographed, searched, fingerprinted and then placed in a holding cell by the defendants.

28. After approximately 12 hours in unlawful custody, plaintiff was transported to Brooklyn County Central Booking and placed in a holding cell.

29. While plaintiff was at Central Booking, plaintiff began to feel dizzy and faint, as plaintiff is a diabetic.

30. Plaintiff was transported to NYU Medical Center to receive treatment for his diabetes.

31. Thereafter, on August 19, 2017, plaintiff was discharged from NYU Medical Center and transported back to Brooklyn Central Booking.

32. Based upon the false, misleading and/or incomplete information provided to the District Attorney's Office by the defendant police officers, a prosecution was initiated against plaintiff.

33. Specifically, the defendant police officers falsely stated to the District Attorney's Office that plaintiff was loitering in a public place for the purpose of gambling.

34. On August 19, 2017, at approximately 2:00 p.m., after being unlawfully detained for approximately 24 hours, plaintiff was arraigned in Kings County Criminal Court, charged with crimes he did not commit and for which the defendant police officers had no legal justification to accuse him of committing and he was released from custody.

35. Plaintiff was unlawfully charged with Loitering.

36. On February 16, 2018, all charges against plaintiff were dismissed and sealed in their entirety.

37. Some of the police officer defendants observed the violation of plaintiff's rights under the Constitution of the United States and New York State Law and did nothing to prevent the unjustifiable stop, question, frisk, search, seizure, false arrest and imprisonment, assault, battery, and use of excessive force against plaintiff.

38. The unlawful stop, question, frisk, search, seizure, false arrest and imprisonment, assault, battery, and use of excessive force against plaintiff by the individually named defendants caused plaintiff to sustain physical, psychological and emotional trauma.

FIRST CAUSE OF ACTION

Violation of Plaintiff's Fourth and Fourteenth Amendment Rights

39. The plaintiff repeats, reiterates and realleges each and every allegation contained in paragraphs marked 1 through 38 with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.

40. The individually named police officer defendants while acting in concert and within the scope of their authority, caused plaintiff to be seized, unlawfully searched, falsely arrested, falsely imprisoned, and denied the right to due process and a fair trial, without reasonable suspicion and/or probable cause, in violation of plaintiff's right to be free of an unreasonable seizure under the Fourth Amendment of the Constitution of the United States and to be free of a deprivation of liberty under the Fourteenth Amendment to the Constitution of the United States.

41. As a result of the aforementioned conduct of defendants, plaintiff sustained injuries, including but not limited to physical, emotional, psychological and economic injuries.

SECOND CAUSE OF ACTION

False Arrest and False Imprisonment

42. The plaintiff repeats, reiterates and realleges each and every allegation contained in paragraphs marked 1 through 41 with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.

43. The acts and conduct of the defendants constitute false arrest and false imprisonment under the laws of the State of New York. Defendants intended to confine plaintiff and, in fact, confined plaintiff, and plaintiff was conscious of the confinement. In addition, plaintiff did not consent to the confinement and the confinement was not otherwise privileged.

44. As a direct and proximate result of such acts, defendants deprived plaintiff of his rights under the laws of the State of New York and the United States Constitution.

45. Defendants were at all times agents, servants, and employees acting within the scope of their employment by the City of New York and the New York City Police Department, which are therefore responsible for their conduct.

46. The City, as the employer of the officer defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

47. As a result of the aforementioned conduct of defendants, plaintiff sustained injuries, including but not limited to physical, economic, emotional and psychological injuries.

THIRD CAUSE OF ACTION

Unlawful Stop, Question, and Frisk

48. The plaintiff repeats, reiterates and realleges each and every allegation contained in paragraphs marked 1 through 47 with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.

49. The illegal approach, pursuit, stop, questioning and frisk employed by defendants herein terminated plaintiff's freedom of movement through means intentionally applied.

50. The conduct of defendants in stopping, frisking, and searching plaintiff were performed under color of law and without any reasonable suspicion of criminality or other constitutionally required grounds.

51. As a direct and proximate result of such acts, defendants deprived plaintiff of his rights under the laws of the State of New York.

52. Defendants were at all times agents, servants, and employees acting within the scope of their employment by the City of New York and the New York City Police Department, which are therefore responsible for their conduct.

53. The City, as the employer of the officer defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

54. As a result of the aforementioned conduct of defendants, plaintiff sustained injuries, including but not limited to physical, economic, emotional and psychological injuries.

FOURTH CAUSE OF ACTION

Unlawful Search

55. The plaintiff repeats, reiterates and realleges each and every allegation contained in paragraphs marked 1 through 54 with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.

56. The illegal approach, pursuit, stop and search employed by defendants herein terminated plaintiff's freedom of movement through means intentionally applied.

57. Defendants lacked probable cause to search plaintiff.

58. As a direct and proximate result of such acts, defendants deprived plaintiff of his rights under the laws of the State of New York.

59. Defendants were at all times agents, servants, and employees acting within the scope of their employment by the City of New York and the New York City Police Department, which are therefore responsible for their conduct.

60. The City, as the employer of the officer defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

61. As a result of the aforementioned conduct of defendants, plaintiff sustained injuries, including but not limited to emotional and psychological injuries.

FIFTH CAUSE OF ACTION

Violation of Plaintiff's Fourth And Fourteenth Amendment Rights

62. The plaintiff repeats, reiterates and realleges each and every allegation contained in paragraphs marked 1 through 61 with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.

63. The use of excessive force by defendants by, amongst other things, by twisting his arms behind his back, and handcuffing plaintiff in an excessively tight manner, constituted objectively unreasonable physical seizures of plaintiff in violation of his rights under the Fourth and Fourteenth Amendments to the Constitution of the United States and to be free of a deprivation of liberty under the Fourteenth Amendment to the Constitution of the United States.

64. Defendants were at all times agents, servants, and employees acting within the scope of his employment by the City of New York and the New York City Police Department, which are therefore responsible for their conduct.

SIXTH CAUSE OF ACTION

Negligent Infliction of Emotional Distress

65. The plaintiff repeats, reiterates and realleges each and every allegation contained in paragraphs marked 1 through 64 with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.

66. By the actions described herein, defendants, each acting individually and in concert with each other, engaged in extreme and outrageous conduct, conduct utterly intolerable in a civilized community, which negligently caused severe emotional distress to plaintiff, Christopher Ellis. The acts and conduct of the defendants were the direct and proximate cause of injury and damage to plaintiff and violated plaintiff's statutory and common law rights as guaranteed by the laws and Constitution of the State of New York.

67. The acts and conduct of the defendants were the direct and proximate cause of injury and damage to plaintiff and violated plaintiff's statutory and common law rights as guaranteed plaintiff by the laws and Constitution of the State of New York.

68. As a direct and proximate result of such acts, defendants deprived plaintiff of his rights under the laws of the State of New York.

69. Defendants were at all times agents, servants, and employees acting within the scope of their employment by the City of New York and the New York City Police Department, which are therefore responsible for their conduct.

70. The City, as the employer of the officer defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

71. As a result of the aforementioned conduct of defendants, plaintiff sustained injuries, including but not limited to emotional and psychological injuries.

SEVENTH CAUSE OF ACTION

Denial of Right to Fair Trial

72. The plaintiff repeats, reiterates and realleges each and every allegation contained in paragraphs marked 1 through 71 with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein

73. Defendants, individually and collectively, manufactured and/or withheld false evidence and forwarded this false evidence to prosecutors in the District Attorney's Office.

74. Defendants filled out false and misleading police reports and forwarded them to prosecutors in the District Attorney's Office.

75. Defendants signed false and misleading criminal court affidavits and forwarded them to prosecutors in the District Attorney's Office.

76. In withholding/creating false evidence against plaintiff Christopher Ellis and in providing/withholding information with respect thereto, defendants violated plaintiff's constitutional right to a fair trial under the New York State Constitution and under the Due Process Clause of the Fifth and Fourteenth Amendments of the United States Constitution.

77. As a result of the foregoing, plaintiff Christopher Ellis sustained, inter alia, loss of liberty, emotional distress, embarrassment and humiliation, lost earnings and deprivation of his constitutional rights.

78. Defendants were at all times agents, servants, and employees acting within the scope of their employment by the City of New York and the New York City Police Department, which are therefore responsible for their conduct.

79. The City, as the employer of the officer defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

80. As a result of the aforementioned conduct of defendants, plaintiff sustained injuries, including but not limited to emotional and psychological injuries.

EIGHTH CAUSE OF ACTION

Negligence

81. The plaintiff repeats, reiterates and realleges each and every allegation contained in paragraphs marked 1 through 80 with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.

82. Defendants owed a duty of care to plaintiff.

83. To the extent defendants claim that the injuries to plaintiff's persons by the defendant police officers was unintentionally caused and that the force used by the defendants against his was unintentional, then the defendants breached that duty of care by accidentally and negligently handcuffing plaintiff in an excessively tight manner, and by assaulting and battering plaintiff.

84. As a direct and proximate result of such acts, defendants deprived plaintiff of his rights under the laws of the State of New York.

85. All of the foregoing occurred without any fault or provocation by plaintiff.

86. Defendants were at all times agents, servants, and employees acting within the scope of their employment by the City of New York and the New York City Police Department, which are therefore responsible for their conduct.

87. The City, as the employer of the officer defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

88. As a result of the aforementioned conduct of defendants, plaintiff sustained injuries, including but not limited to emotional and psychological injuries.

NINTH CAUSE OF ACTION

Assault

89. The plaintiff repeats, reiterates and realleges each and every allegation contained in paragraphs marked 1 through 88 with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.

90. Defendants, their agents, servants and employees, acting within the scope of his employment, intentionally, willfully and maliciously assaulted plaintiff in that they had the real or apparent ability to cause imminent harmful and/or offensive bodily contact and intentionally did a violent and/or menacing act which threatened such contact to the plaintiff, that such acts caused apprehension of such contact in the plaintiff.

91. As a direct and proximate result of such acts, defendants deprived plaintiff of his rights under the laws of the State of New York.

92. Defendants were at all times agents, servants, and employees acting within the scope of their employment by the City of New York and the New York City Police Department, which are therefore responsible for their conduct.

93. The City, as the employer of the officer defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

94. As a result of the aforementioned conduct of defendants, plaintiff sustained injuries, including but not limited to emotional and psychological injuries.

TENTH CAUSE OF ACTION

Battery

95. The plaintiff repeats, reiterates and realleges each and every allegation contained in paragraphs marked 1 through 94 with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.

96. Defendants, their agents, servants and employees, acting within the scope of their employment, intentionally, willfully and maliciously battered plaintiff, and with the intention of causing harmful and/or offensive bodily contact to the plaintiff and caused such battery.

97. As a direct and proximate result of such acts, defendants deprived plaintiff of his rights under the laws of the State of New York.

98. Defendants were at all times agents, servants, and employees acting within the scope of their employment by the City of New York and the New York City Police Department, which are therefore responsible for their conduct.

99. The City, as the employer of the officer defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

100. As a result of the aforementioned conduct of defendants, plaintiff sustained injuries, including but not limited to emotional and psychological injuries.

ELEVENTH CAUSE OF ACTION

Negligent Hiring, Retention, Training and Supervision

101. The plaintiff repeats, reiterates and realleges each and every allegation contained in paragraphs marked 1 through 100 with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.

102. The City of New York and its employees, servants and/or agents acting within the scope of their employment did negligently hire, retain, train and supervise defendants, individuals who were unfit for the performance of police duties on the aforementioned dates at the aforementioned locations.

103. As a result of the aforementioned conduct of defendants, plaintiff sustained injuries, including but not limited to emotional and psychological injuries.

TWELVTH CAUSE OF ACTION

Failure to Intervene

104. The plaintiff repeats, reiterates and realleges each and every allegation contained in paragraphs marked 1 through 103 with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.

105. The defendants that did not physically touch plaintiff, but were present when other officers violated plaintiff's Constitutional Rights had an affirmative duty to intervene on behalf of plaintiff, whose constitutional rights were being violated in their presence by other officers.

106. Defendants failed to intervene to prevent the unlawful conduct described herein.

107. As a result of the foregoing, plaintiff's liberty was restricted for an extended period of time, he was put in fear of his safety, and he was humiliated and subject to other physical constraints.

108. As a direct and proximate result of such acts, defendants deprived plaintiff of his rights under the laws of the State of New York.

109. Defendants were at all times agents, servants, and employees acting within the scope of their employment by the City of New York and the New York City Police Department, which are therefore responsible for their conduct.

110. The City, as the employer of the officer defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

111. As a result of the aforementioned conduct of defendants, plaintiff sustained injuries, including but not limited to emotional and psychological injuries.

JURY DEMAND

112. Plaintiff hereby demands trial by jury of all issues properly triable thereby.

PRAYER FOR RELIEF

WHEREFORE, plaintiff Christopher Ellis demands judgment against the defendants on each cause of action in amounts to be determined upon the trial of this action which exceeds the jurisdiction of lower courts, inclusive of punitive damages and attorneys' fees inclusive of costs and disbursements of this action, interest and such other relief as is appropriate under the law. That the plaintiff recover the cost of the suit herein, including reasonable attorney's fees pursuant to 42 U.S.C. § 1988.

Dated: New York, New York
November 16, 2018

By: /s/
STUART E. JACOBS
DAVID M. HAZAN
JACOBS & HAZAN, LLP
Attorneys for Plaintiff
30 Vesey Street, 4th Floor
New York, NY 10007
(212) 577-2690

TO: City of New York, Corporation Counsel, 100 Church Street, NY, NY 10007
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Ave, Brooklyn, NY 11221
SERGEANT MICHAEL PETRONE, 81st Precinct, 30 Ralph Ave, Brooklyn, NY 11221

ATTORNEY'S VERIFICATION

STUART E. JACOBS, an attorney duly admitted to practice before the Courts of the State of New York, affirms the following to be true under the penalties of perjury:

I am a partner of the law firm of **JACOBS & HAZAN, LLP**, I have read the annexed **VERIFIED COMPLAINT** and know the contents thereof, and the same are true to my knowledge, except those matters therein which are stated to be alleged upon information and belief, and as to those matters I believe them to be true. My belief, as to those matters therein not stated upon knowledge, is based upon facts, records, and other pertinent information contained in my files. The reason this verification is made by me and not Plaintiff is because plaintiff does not reside in the county wherein I maintain my office.

DATED: New York, New York
November 16, 2018

/s/
STUART E. JACOBS